Examples of Phonetic Symbols Found in Standard American English

Note: Because English spelling does not have a one-to-one correspondence with sounds, underlining the letter in example words can be difficult. For example, we have underlined the <x> in *exceed* to indicate both [k] and [s], because the letter <x> represents a series of two sounds: [ks]. For each symbol, think carefully bout how the sound occurs in the example words.

a. Consonants

i. Non-Syllabic Consonants

Symbol	*Sample Words*
[p]	pit, tip, spit, hiccough, appear
[b]	ball, globe, amble, brick, bubble
[t]	tag, pat, stick, pterodactyl, stuffed
[d]	dip, card, drop, loved, batted
[k]	kit, scoot, character, critique, exceed
[g]	guard, bag, finger, designate, Pittsburgh
[ʔ]	uh-oh, hatrack, Batman
[f]	foot, laugh, philosophy, coffee, carafe
[v]	vest, dove, gravel, anvil, average
[θ]	through, wrath, thistle, ether, teeth
[ð]	the, their, mother, either, teethe
[s]	soap, psychology, packs, descent, peace, exceed
[z]	zip, roads, kisses, Xerox, design
[ʃ]	shy, mission, nation, glacial, sure
[ʒ]	measure, vision, azure, casualty, decision
[h]	who, hat, rehash, hole, whole
[ʧ]	choke, match, feature, righteous, constituent
[ʤ]	judge, George, Jell-O, region, residual
[m]	moose, lamb, smack, amnesty, ample
[n]	nap, design, snow, know, mnemonic
[ŋ]	lung, think, finger, singer, ankle
[l]	leaf, feel, Lloyd, mild, applaud
[ɹ]	reef, fear, Harris, prune, carp
[ɾ]	writer, butter, udder, clutter, cuter
[w]	with, swim, mowing, queen, twilight
[ʍ]	which, where, what, whale, why
[j]	you, beautiful, feud, use, yell

ii. Syllabic Consonants

Symbol	*Sample Words*
[m̩]	possum, chasm, Adam, bottomless
[n̩]	button, chicken, lesson, kittenish
[l̩]	little, single, simple, stabilize
[ɹ̩]	ladder, singer, burp, percent

b. Vowels

i. Monophthongs (Simple Vowels)

Symbol	*Examples*
[i]	beat, we, believe, people, money, dean
[ɪ]	bit, consist, injury, malignant, gym, business
[ɛ]	bet, reception, says, guest, bend
[æ]	bat, laugh, anger, bang, comrade, rally, hand
[u]	boot, who, sewer, duty, through, dune
[ʊ]	put, foot, butcher, boogie-woogie, could
[ɔ]	bought, caught, wrong, stalk, core
[ɑ]	pot, father, sergeant, honor, hospital, bomb
[ʌ]	but, tough, another, oven, fungus
[ə]	among, Asia, enough, famous, harmony

ii. Diphthongs (Complex Vowels)

Symbol	*Examples*
[ɑɪ]	I, bite, Stein, aisle, choir, island, fine
[ɑʊ]	bout, brown, doubt, flower, loud
[ɔɪ]	boy, doily, rejoice, perestroika, annoy
[oʊ]	oh, boat, beau, grow, though, over
[eɪ]	bait, reign, great, they, gauge, age